CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Monday, November 9, 2026 No. 229 12 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. North Korean envoy Kim Song Nam returned from Beijing after meeting Cai Qi and Wang Yi, fueling Kim Jong Un–Xi summit speculation ahead of APEC.
2. Ukrainian President Zelensky said Russia used North Korean KN-23 short-range ballistic missiles to strike a key Ukrainian energy facility on Saturday.
3. South Korea's Fair Trade Commission fined Coupang *$220 million* for abusing dominance in the food delivery market.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,018.85	1,345.62	$94.71	39%	Nov 8	3.00%
−0.8%	−0.8%	−3.7%	flat Oct 27-29	1 day ago	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

Dong-A Ilbo, NK-Russia-China

North Korean envoy's Beijing visit fuels Kim-Xi summit speculation ahead of APEC

Kim Song Nam, the Workers' Party international secretary and Pyongyang's top liaison to Beijing, returned home November 7 after a five-day China visit during which he met Politburo Standing Committee member Cai Qi and Foreign Minister **Wang Yi**. The visit came ten days before US President Donald Trump is due to attend the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Shenzhen on November 18, and followed Kim Jong Un's unannounced day trip to Dandong on October 24. Analysts cited in Dong-A Ilbo suggest Kim Song Nam may have relayed messages toward Washington through Beijing, while the back-to-back high-level contacts have fueled speculation about a preparatory visit by Kim Jong Un and a summit with Xi.

NK News, NK-Russia-China

Zelensky says Russia used North Korean KN-23 missiles to strike Ukrainian energy facility

Ukrainian President **Volodymyr Zelensky** said Saturday that Russia used North Korean KN-23 short-range ballistic missiles to damage a key Ukrainian energy facility, calling it proof that international sanctions must be strengthened.

Zelensky said preliminary findings confirmed KN-23 use, naming the model for the first time in public attribution, previous statements had referred generically to 'North Korean ballistic missiles.' Ukraine's military is separately investigating the strike.

Reuters, ROK Economy

South Korea fines Coupang $220 million for abusing dominance in food delivery market

South Korea's Fair Trade Commission fined **Coupang** *$220 million* for abusing its dominant position in the food delivery market, regulators confirmed. SBS reported separately that the total combined fines against Coupang Eats and Baemin reached approximately 630 billion won ($463 million) for pressuring merchants to sell at lower prices, limiting price competition and raising costs for consumers.

02 OVERNIGHT

Yonhap, US-Korea

US Ambassador Steel marks 100 days: alliance modernization, shipbuilding, SMR cooperation as priorities

Alliance modernization, economic opportunity, and regional challenges named as the three pillars.

Korea Times, ROK Politics

Special counsel bill deepens partisan divide over Lee Jae-myung's suspended criminal trials

Justice minister nominee declined to commit on dropping charges, saying only 'truth-finding' is the focus.

Korea Times, ROK Politics

Election special counsel raids ballot machine firms over suspected NEC contract collusion

Team led by special counsel Lee Tae-han found NEC spent roughly 17.5 billion won over a decade on two firms.

Korea Economic Daily, ROK Economy

Horizon Energy to more than double plastic-to-oil capacity in South Korea

Expansion at the facility targets growing domestic demand for chemical recycling-based fuel.

Yonhap, ROK Politics

Lee meets Uzbek Senate speaker, calls for parliamentary support on critical minerals and AI cooperation

Lee referenced the September summit with Uzbek President Mirziyoyev and urged the Senate speaker to advance bilateral agreements.

Korea.net, ROK Politics

Lee-Ramos-Horta summit: ROK and Timor-Leste commit to IP, climate, and law enforcement cooperation

Summit held November 6 at Cheong Wa Dae; 25th independence anniversary of both nations and ties falls next year.

NK News, DPRK

NK News defector column: scientists structurally marginalized in DPRK despite weapons program emphasis

Defector account describes how political constraints override technical expertise even in prioritized research fields.

03 STAT OF THE DAY

$220M

FTC fine levied on Coupang for food delivery market abuse

South Korea's Fair Trade Commission issued the fine against Coupang for abusing dominance in the food delivery market, the largest such penalty in the sector.

Reuters, Nov 9

04 PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

No public appearance today, last seen 1 day ago

No KCNA watch flag. 7 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

> **Bottom line:** State media led with the agricultural workers' congress and domestic welfare content; all five recent weapons tests remain absent from the domestic news agenda.

05 | ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Monday, November 9, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Second Vice Minister Kim Jina

Signs IHO Infrastructure Center establishment agreement in Busan; meets IHO Secretary-General

Second Vice Minister **Kim Jina** met International Hydrographic Organization Secretary-General **Luigi Sinapi** at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Seoul on November 9 and signed the agreement establishing the IHO Infrastructure Center in Busan. The center, the first IHO overseas office, will oversee development and validation of the S-100 next-generation digital marine information standard.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**
Reported **Newsis**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Climate Ambassador Kang Kum-sil

Designated presidential envoy to COP31 leaders summit in Antalya, November 11-12

Global Climate and Environment Ambassador **Kang Kum-sil** will attend the COP31 Antalya Leaders Summit on November 11-12 as a special presidential envoy, the foreign ministry announced. Kang will present the government's K-Green Transformation (K-GX) strategy and seek international support for Paris Agreement implementation.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF NATIONAL DEFENSE

Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul

Meets alumni leaders of three military academies on integrated academy reform

Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul met representatives of the Army, Navy, and Air Force academy alumni associations on November 9 to exchange views on the military academy education reform and integration plan. The ministry is refining its National Military Academy consolidation proposal and plans to explain the optimal framework to the public.

Ministry of National Defense on X

MINISTRY OF TRADE, INDUSTRY AND ENERGY

Trade Minister (trade bureau chief)

Meets Hungarian deputy prime minister on Korean battery firms' operational difficulties

South Korea's trade bureau chief met Hungary's deputy prime minister to discuss the operational difficulties facing Korean battery companies, including **Samsung SDI** and **SK On**, operating in Hungary, and to strengthen their environmental partnership. The meeting follows a government push to reinforce ESG cooperation for Korean battery manufacturers in Europe.

heraldcorp

PERSONNEL CHANGES

Lee Yong-cheol **NOMINATED**
Minister of Justice (nominee)
Justice minister nominee Lee Yong-cheol declined to give a direct answer Monday on whether he would order the withdrawal of charges against President Lee Jae-myung, saying he would focus 'exclusively on truth-finding in accordance with law and principles.' Lee has a 30-year legal career including roughly 10 years as a notary.

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Special counsel bill (fabricated prosecution special counsel) cleared for promulgation; Blue House defers cabinet vote to next week

National Assembly Plenary

The Blue House announced November 9 that the so-called 'fabricated prosecution special counsel bill,' which passed the National Assembly plenary on November 6, will not be submitted to the November 10 cabinet meeting and will instead be placed on the agenda at the following week's session. Under normal procedure, laws passed by the Assembly are promulgated within a set period after government transmission.

Opposition lawmakers attack government's Future Response Fund as 'Future Abandonment Fund'

Policy Committee

People Power Party lawmakers in the Policy Committee attacked the Lee administration's proposed Future Response Fund, calling it a 'Future Abandonment Fund' and a 'high-interest overdraft account.' The government issued a press clarification denying that the fund creates optical distortions in fiscal indicators.

06 | US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and automobiles at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff in force. Section 301 investigations launched March 11, 2026 against South Korea and 15 other partners are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B energy purchases; no official drawdown figure reported to date.

07 | CAPITOL HILL

Hankook Ilbo, Legislation

Democratic-controlled Congress moves to advance $20 trillion won Ukraine aid and tighten Russia sanctions

The measures reflect Democratic majority priorities diverging from the Republican White House's posture on the Russia-Ukraine conflict.

jkn.co.kr, Statement

Democratic Congress, hardline White House: Seoul must persuade both sides separately, analysts say

South Korea faces the challenge of engaging a Democratic-controlled Congress skeptical of executive-led investment deals and a Republican administration pressing for alliance cost-sharing and trade commitments simultaneously, according to Korean-language analysis of the midterm results.

08 NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Newsis, China-Korea

Iran warns South Korea to refrain from Hormuz involvement, cites 60 years of bilateral ties

Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson said the best help South Korea can offer is to avoid involvement in the 'already complex' Hormuz situation, warning that joining what Tehran called a US military campaign against Iran would damage over 60 years of bilateral relations. The warning came hours after Defense Minister Kang Shin-chul defended the Cheonghae Unit expansion at the National Assembly.

09 KOREA AND THE WORLD

Korea JoongAng Daily, Ukraine, Aid

Seoul to commit $100 million in Ukraine aid despite lingering diplomatic tensions

South Korea plans to commit *$100 million* in Ukraine aid despite ongoing diplomatic tensions, Korea JoongAng Daily reported. The commitment comes as the Democratic-controlled US Congress is simultaneously pushing expanded Ukraine support legislation.

Vietnam Investment Review - VIR, Southeast Asia, Trade

South Korean firms stay put in Vietnam despite rising costs

South Korean companies operating in Vietnam are maintaining their presence despite rising labor and operational costs, the Vietnam Investment Review reported. Vietnam remains South Korea's largest manufacturing base in Southeast Asia for electronics and consumer goods.

10 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

The Times of India

Samsung set to become South Korea's first company with 200 trillion won in cash

Samsung is on track to become South Korea's first company to hold *200 trillion won* in cash, according to reporting. The milestone reflects accumulated reserves across Samsung's semiconductor, display and consumer electronics divisions.

Samsung

Kyunghyang Shinmun

Samsung and Hyundai Motor form strategic partnership in mobility and robotics

Samsung and **Hyundai Motor Group** senior executives gathered at Samsung Electronics' Yongin campus on November 9 to formalize a strategic partnership in future mobility and physical AI, expanding cooperation beyond their existing battery and electronics supply relationship. The two groups aim to elevate the partnership to cover advanced industrial sectors.

Samsung Hyundai Motor Group

Maeil Business

Four major banks' non-performing SME loans hit warning level, delinquency rate double that of large firms

The four major South Korean banks face a mounting 'hollow loan' problem in small and medium enterprise lending, with non-performing loans rising sharply as regulators push productive finance expansion. The SME loan delinquency rate is running at approximately double that for large corporations, raising financial stability concerns.

busan

South Korea's Digital Asset Act draft due this month, major shareholder stake cap likely at 15-20%

The government's Digital Asset Act bill is expected to be released publicly this month, with the major shareholder stake cap in cryptocurrency exchanges likely set at 15-20%, according to Busan Ilbo. The legislation follows the Financial Services Commission's earlier disclosure that the bill would be published in November.

11 | UPCOMING

NOV 10 — **IHO Infrastructure Center opening ceremony, Busan**
The International Hydrographic Organization Infrastructure Center opens at Busan International Finance Center II, with delegations from about 30 countries attending.

NOV 10 — **Korean Peninsula Peace Tourism seminar, Seoul**
The Unification Ministry-backed inter-Korean Exchange Cooperation Support Association holds an international seminar on cross-border peace tourism at Seoul Central Post Office.

NOV 11 — **COP31 Antalya Leaders Summit, ROK presidential envoy attends**
Climate Ambassador Kang Kum-sil attends the COP31 leaders summit in Antalya, Turkey as a special presidential envoy; about 80 nations' leaders expected.

NOV 17 — **10th US-ROK Joint Public-Private Economic Forum, Hudson Institute**
Hudson Institute hosts the tenth US-ROK Joint Economic Forum, with ROK Second Vice Minister Kim Jina and senior US and Korean officials assessing the bilateral economic partnership.

NOV 17 — **Special counsel bill cabinet vote expected**
The Blue House said the fabricated prosecution special counsel bill promulgation order will be submitted to the cabinet meeting the week of November 17.

NOV 18 — **APEC summit, Shenzhen, Trump attends**
US President Trump attends the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit in Shenzhen, China, ten days after North Korean envoy Kim Song Nam's Beijing meetings.

12 | ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

FM Cho Hyun (@FMChoHyun), November 9

"I am deeply saddened by the tragic mass shooting in Poland which has resulted in the loss of innocent lives. I extend my deepest condolences to the victims and their bereaved families. I recently met Polish Foreign Minister Sikorski on the sidelines of the G20 Foreign Ministers Meeting in Atlanta and reaffirmed the enduring friendly and cooperative relationship between Korea and Poland."

FM Cho Hyun attended the G20 Foreign Ministers Meeting in Atlanta, where he met Polish FM Sikorski, the first post-election face-to-face with a G20 counterpart following the US midterm results. **View on X**

MSIT Minister (@msitminister), November 9

"I have arrived in Doha, Qatar to attend the ITU Plenipotentiary Conference (ITU PP-26). South Korea is seeking its 10th consecutive election to the ITU Council and a seat on the Radio Regulations Board. AI and digital technology now determine national competitiveness."

South Korea's bid for a 10th consecutive ITU Council seat and a Radio Regulations Board position tracks the government's stated goal of leading global digital governance. **View on X**

US Forces Korea (@USForcesKorea), November 9

"USFK joined the Korea-America Association's Friendship Night Banquet, celebrating 63 years of friendship and support for the ROK-US Alliance. Together, we honor shared sacrifices and strengthen our commitment to peace and security."

The Korea-America Association banquet marks a standing bilateral civil-military engagement channel; the event follows USFK Commander Gen. Xavier Brunson's recent Tokyo meeting with Japan's defense minister. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

COMMENTARY

Seoul's deal with Trump now hinges on two powers in Washington. The Korea Herald analysis argues that the Democratic Congress will push on labor, environment and transparency provisions that could complicate implementation of the US-Korea Strategic Trade and Investment Deal framework. The piece notes Seoul faces the structural challenge of persuading a White House and a Congress with divergent priorities on trade, investment, and Korea policy simultaneously. (The Korea Herald)

U.S. Midterms: No Benefits for U.S.-South Korea Relations. The Chosun Ilbo editorial argues that divided Washington creates a no-win dynamic for Korean diplomacy, with Democratic congressional priorities diverging from Seoul's existing deal architecture with the Trump White House. The piece frames the midterm result as a complication rather than an opportunity for Korean policymakers. (Chosun Ilbo)

Post-Election Thoughts. The CSIS trade analysis finds that leadership on the House Ways and Means and Senate Finance Committees survived the Democratic sweep, limiting near-term disruption to trade legislation. The piece identifies the return of Sherrod Brown to the Senate as a wildcard for the Finance Committee's trade posture and notes the composition changes will shape any Section 301 or tariff legislation in the new Congress. (CSIS)

13 | PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

0 pts vs Oct 13-15
Gallup Korea
October 27-29, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 7 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
35%	30%	28%

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 1 week old (October 27-29, 2026).

Gallup Korea spotlight (Nov 08, 2026): Public Trust in Police: 57% of Koreans said they do not trust the police, and 58% expressed distrust in the prosecution, per Gallup Korea polling released November 8, 2026.

14 | THE WIRE

US-KOREA

NK News

US reaffirms no change in wartime OPCON transfer conditions, ROK lawmaker says

Democratic Party lawmaker **Jin Sung-joon** said the US Indo-Pacific Command reaffirmed to him during a Hawaii visit that the conditions-based agreement to transfer wartime operational control (OPCON) to South Korea remains unchanged. The US side acknowledged 'policy-related factors' may come into play but held to the existing bilateral framework.

Yonhap News Agency

Defense minister says Cheonghae Unit expansion prepares for Hormuz threats 'that cannot be entirely ruled out'

Defense Minister **Kang Shin-chul** told the National Assembly that expanding the Cheonghae anti-piracy unit's operational zone from the Somalia coast to south of Oman, and adding mine-sweeping vehicles and a P-8A Poseidon aircraft, is to prepare for threats that 'cannot be entirely ruled out' near the Strait of Hormuz. Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson separately warned Seoul the same day to refrain from involvement in the Hormuz situation.

Yonhap News Agency

Hanwha Aerospace to conduct ship-based Chunmoo missile tests off US coast this month

Hanwha Aerospace's US subsidiary plans two test-firings of its Chunmoo multiple rocket launcher system from a vessel off the southern US coast later in November, testing the land-based system's suitability for naval deployment. The tests follow an April agreement with Florida-based Magnet Defense to develop a containerized Chunmoo launcher for the H38 medium unmanned surface vessel.

Reuters

Seoul says $10 billion US nuclear project remittance requires full feasibility review

South Korea's government said remitting funds for the *$10 billion* US nuclear reactor project under the $350B investment pledge requires a full feasibility review before money can be transferred. The feasibility requirement applies to the planned eight large-scale US reactor deal, where Seoul had sought a roughly 20 percent Westinghouse stake.

DPRK

NK News

US Treasury blacklists Seychelles crypto exchange for $16.7B in North Korean laundering links

The US Treasury Department's Financial Crimes Enforcement Network issued an order prohibiting US financial institutions from processing transfers to a Seychelles-based cryptocurrency exchange linked to *at least $16.7 billion* in illicit transactions, including North Korean money laundering.

TECHNOLOGY

Bloomberg

Nvidia controversy throws high-profile Korea event into disarray

The Nvidia CEO spy allegations threw a planned high-profile Korea event into disarray, with the CEO's daughter canceling her planned visit to South Korea. South Korean chipmakers Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix could face tighter export compliance requirements if US authorities step up scrutiny of Nvidia's AI chip shipments to China, the Korea Herald reported.

15 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

No new reporting on any of the 11 monitored sites since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 229

TOMORROW

IHO Infrastructure Center opening ceremony, Busan

Korean Peninsula Peace Tourism seminar, Seoul

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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